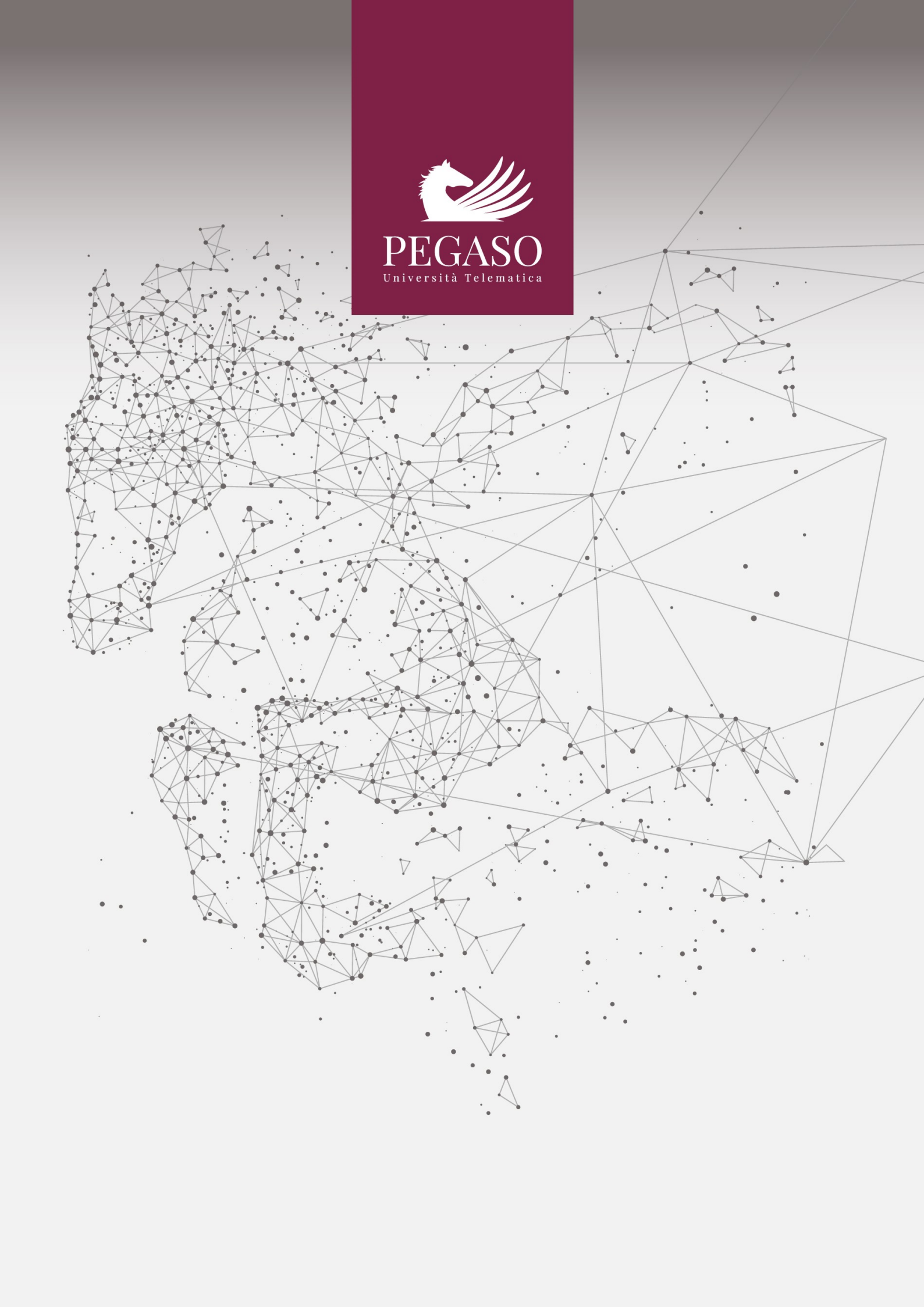

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1. Introduction to the Passive

In English we use the passive voice to change the focus of the sentence. We often use the passive when we prefer not to mention who or what does the action (for instance, when the agent is not known, or it's obvious) so that we can start a sentence with the most important or most logical information.

Passive Form

To form the passive, use the appropriate tense of be + past participle.

Present Simple

Most phone calls are made on mobile phones.

Present Continuous

Calls are being made every day.

Past Simple

The first email was sent in the twentieth century.

Past Continuous

I thought / was being asked to help.

Present Perfect

Millions of text messages have been sent.

Past Perfect

Once personal computers had been invented, they spread quickly.

Future Will

She'll be given her own room.

Future Perfect

The arrangements will have been made by the end of the week

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Going To

The event is going to be organized by the manager.

Modals

The machine must have been left switched on.

Messages may not be delivered immediately.

-ing

Our dog doesn't like being left on his own

Present Infinitive

They hope to be chosen to take part.

Perfect Infinitive

I was happy to have been selected for the team.

Be Careful:

1. Verbs that do not take an object (e.g. ache, arrive, sit down) do not have passive forms. It is not possible to say I was ached.

2. For verbs with two objects, one of them a person, the passive sentence usually begins with the person.

Someone gave Mary a present. → Mary was given a present. (NOT A present was given to Mary.)

3. The verbs **make, hear, see, help** are followed by the infinitive without to in active sentences, but the infinitive with to in passive sentences.

They made him go home. - He was made to go home.

4. **Let** does not have a passive form. We use be allowed to in the passive.

They don't let us talk in class. — We are not allowed to talk in class

Passive Use

- to talk about actions, events and processes when the action, event or process is seen as more important than the agent. This is often the case in formal or scientific writing.

The equipment was checked carefully.

Rats have been trained to open boxes.

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- to put new information later in the sentence.

Hamlet was written by Shakespeare.

By + agent

When we are interested in the agent, we use the preposition **by**.

He was saved by his mobile phone.

The team were guided by a local climber

Passive Reporting Verbs

We often use reporting verbs such as **believe, claim, report, say, think** in the following impersonal passive structures when we don't know or don't wish to specify the subject.

It + be + verb + that

It is thought that the criminal is a local man. (= present)

It was claimed that the minister had been involved. (= past)

subject + be + reporting verb + infinitive

The criminal is thought to be a local man. (= present)

The minister was claimed to have been involved.[1]

[1] J. Bell and A. Thomas, *Gold First Coursebook New Edition*, Essex, Pearson Education Limited, 2014 (172)

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2. Active vs. Passive

An active sentence like I drank two cups of coffee has the subject first (the person or thing that does the verb), followed by the verb, and finally the object (the person or thing that the action happens to).

So, in this example, the subject is 'I', the verb is 'drank' and the object is 'two cups of coffee'.

But, we don't always need to make sentences this way. We might want to put the object first, or perhaps we don't want to say who did something. This can happen for lots of reasons. In this case, we can use a passive, which puts the object first:

Two cups of coffee were drunk (we can add 'by me' if we want, but it isn't necessary).

We make the passive by putting the verb 'to be' into whatever tense we need and then adding the past participle.

Tense	**Active**	**Passive**
present simple	I **make** a cake.	A cake **is made** (by me).
present continuous	I **am making** a cake.	A cake **is being made** (by me).
past simple	I **made** a cake.	A cake **was made** (by me).
past continuous	I **was making** a cake.	A cake **was being made** (by me).
present perfect	I **have made** a cake.	A cake **has been made** (by me).
pres. perf. continuous	I **have been making** a cake.	A cake **has been being made** (by me).
past perfect	I **had made** a cake.	A cake **had been made** (by me).
future simple	I **will make** a cake.	A cake **will be made** (by me).
future perfect	I **will have made** a cake.	A cake **will have been made** (by me).

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Verbs with Two Objects

Some verbs that have two objects can make two different active sentences, and so two different passive sentences too:

Give

Active: He gave me the book / He gave the book to me.

You can choose either of the two objects to be the subject of the passive sentence.

Passive: I was given the book (by him)/ The book was given to me (by him).

Other verbs like this are: ask, offer, teach, tell, lend, promise, sell, throw.

The Passive in Subordinate Clauses

You can make the passive in a subordinate clause that has a subject and a normal conjugated verb. This is really the same as a normal passive.

Active: I thought that Mary had kissed John.

Passive: I thought that John had been kissed by Mary.

Active: He knew that people had built the church in 1915.

Passive: He knew that the church had been built in 1915.

The Passive Gerund and Infinitive

You can also make the passive using a passive gerund or a passive infinitive in the same place as a normal gerund or infinitive.

The child loves being cuddled.

She would like to be promoted.

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3. Focus on Passive Use

When should we use the Passive?

1: When we want to change the focus of the sentence

The Mona Lisa was painted by Leonardo Da Vinci. (We are more interested in the painting than the artist in this sentence)

2: When who or what causes the action is unknown or unimportant or obvious or 'people in general'

He was arrested (obvious agent, the police).

My bike has been stolen (unknown agent).

The road is being repaired (unimportant agent).

The form can be obtained from the post office (people in general).

3: In factual or scientific writing

The chemical is placed in a test tube and the data entered into the computer.

4: In formal writing instead of using someone/ people/ they (these can be used in speaking or informal writing)

The brochure will be finished next month.

5: In order to put the new information at the end of the sentence to improve style

Three books are used regularly in the class. The books were written by Dr. Bell. ('Dr. Bell wrote the books' sound clumsy).

6: When the subject is very long

I was surprised by how well the students did in the test. (More natural than: 'how well the students did in the test surprised me').

EXERCISES

Rewrite these sentences. Instead of using 'people', 'somebody', or 'they', write a passive sentence with an appropriate verb form.

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ex. We can solve the problem. The problem can be solved.

1. Someone had reported the theft to the police.

2. Someone has given £1,000 to the charity.

3. Someone will demonstrate the program to the students.

4. Someone explained the procedure to me.

5. People are destroying large areas of forest every day.

6. Somebody has bought the land next to the university.

7. I hope they will have completed all the marking by tomorrow.

8. They should have finished the library by the time you arrive.

9. People expect better results soon.

10. Students should send their complaints to the head of department.

11. They had to postpone the lecture because of illness.

12. An electrical fault could have caused the fire.

13. They are going to hold next year's conference in Birmingham.

14. Everyone knows this fact very well.

15. They opened the new lecture theatre only last month.

16. You must write the answers on the examination paper in black ink.

17. They are now manufacturing this type of computer in Korea.

18. Someone should investigate the problem.

Find and correct the mistakes with passive forms in the following sentences.

19. Pasta is always serve with your meal so there's no need to order it separately.

20. Are you been picked up at the airport or shall I meet you there?

21. Turkey are eaten every year at Thanksgiving in the USA.

22. The cookbook book was wrote by a famous television chef.

23. In the past, women was expected to do all the cleaning.

24 Too much fast food are eaten nowadays - people should be educated about healthy eating

25. It is believe that people should be informed about the health benefits of regular exercise.

26. People are expected throw their litter in the trash cans, not on the street..

27. Orders for our special Chinese menu must placed at least two days in advance.

28. She was always being ask to prepare the food for weddings since everyone knew she was such a good cook.

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Translate the following sentences into Italian.

29. Active: “The researcher conducted the experiment.”
30. Passive: “The experiment was conducted by the researcher.”
31. Active: “The virus infected the cells.”
32. Passive: “The cells were infected by the virus.”
33. Active: “The plant absorbed water through its roots.”
34. Passive: “Water was absorbed by the plant through its roots.
35. Active: “The bacteria produce the enzyme.”
36. Passive: “The enzyme is produced by the bacteria.”

EXERCISE ANSWER KEY

1. The theft had been reported to the police.
2. 1000 pounds has been given to charity.
3. The program will be demonstrated to the students.
4. The procedure was explained to me.
5. Large areas of forest are being destroyed every day.
6. The land next to the university has been bought.
7. I hope all the marketing will have been completed by tomorrow.
8. The library should have been finished by the time you arrive.
9. Better results are expected soon.
10. Complaints should be sent to the head of department.
11. The lecture had to be postponed because of illness.
12. The fire could have been caused by an electrical fault.
13. Next year‘s conference is going to be held in Birmingham.
14. This fact is known very well by everyone.
15. The new lecture theater was opened only last month.
16. The answers must be written on the examination paper in black ink.
17. This type of computer in Korea is now being manufactured.
18. The problem should be investigated.
19. Pasta is always served with your meal.
20. Are you being picked up?
21. Turkey isn’t eaten every year.
22. The cookbook book was written by a famous television chef.

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23. In the past, women were expected to do all the cleaning.
24. Too much fast food is eaten nowadays.
25. It is believed that people should be informed.
26. People are expected to throw their litter in the trash cans.
27. Orders for our special Chinese menu must be placed at least two days in advance.
28. She was always being asked to prepare the food.
29. Il ricercatore ha condotto l'esperimento.
30. L'esperimento è stato condotto dal ricercatore.
31. Il virus ha infettato le cellule.
32. Le cellule sono state infettate dal virus.
33. La pianta ha assorbito l'acqua attraverso le radici.
34. L'acqua è stata assorbita dalla pianta attraverso le radici.
35. I batteri producono l'enzima.
36. L'enzima è prodotto dai batteri.

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